

father's hair"—and is brought up by his grand-uncle Big Grandfather, a legendary maker of Hindu epics in the Madras film industry. The author is a professor of media studies in San Francisco, whose previous books include *The Ideals of the Indian Cinema* and *Becoming a Global Audience: Longing and Belonging in Indian Music Television*. His interest in films has clearly informed his fiction, and his treatment of Parashuram's childhood in a house filled with "filmy" people—script writers, set designers, lyricists, actors—is wonderfully vibrant. Fate, as he finds out, however, does not intend him to be a film star as he so desperately wants. The industry, in its infinite fickleness, betrays Big Grandfather and the world Parashuram knew comes crumbling down along with his grand-uncle's career. Years later, he has another brush with the film world, this time as a chaperone to Baby Kumari, a child actor who now contests the elections against SLK, a superstar who joined politics. Sounds familiar? Cleverly

While Rajan's book is centred around a funeral, when all the dirty little secrets of various members of a family tumble out, a constant strain of loss runs through Juluri's narrative, which is about families that may not be related by blood.

satirical, this section of the book illustrates the "drama" of politics, the fakery and false promises that a campaign involves. While this juxtaposition is nothing new, Juluri succeeds because he offers no judgement—the process is described with an amused air of someone watching an entertaining movie seen many times before. You know the ending, but the fun is in the predictability.

Parashuram's life changes when he meets a woman named AK. She becomes his mentor, his elder sister, his only family. A mother he never had. Apart from taking him under her wing, she arranges for him to live in America, and study creative writing in a small Midwestern university. Then she ensconces him in San Francisco, a city where he finally finds inspiration to write. All, however, is not well, and the novel crashes toward a resounding climax—complete with the attacks on the Twin Towers in the background. *The Mythologist* throws up pertinent issues connected to media and television—how, for instance, the fabrication of news today is nothing short of melodrama, worthy of a script as elaborate as any that Big Grandfather can come up with.

(The author is a freelance writer based in Shillong)

Point of Intersection

Cadavers and colonialism are unlikely partners in a potent time-travelling thriller

| By Bunny Suraiya |



THE QUARANTINE PAPERS

by KALPISH RATNA
HarperCollins India
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 404

This complex novel begins on the day when the Babri Masjid is brought down by swarming, saffron-banner-waving karsevaks. Panic engulfs Mumbai's Muslim-inhabited districts. The police are sardonic witnesses to the rioting that breaks out and soon the dead and dying begin to fill the morgues and hospitals. In an unrelated incident, an old woman, Shakuntala Salwe, dies defending—chipko-style—her one-room hut near the Bombay Arts College, the target of another, officially sanctioned, demolition. When she is found by Ratan Oak, she is clutching in her hand a crumbling, yellowed piece of paper dating back to March 1897. It is an official permit made out by the Bombay Plague Committee allowing one Khorsheed Alam "to make use of the Mahim-Bandorli Causeway without detention", and it has been preserved since 1897 within the pages of a book entitled *Beast and Man in India* authored by John Lockwood Kipling, father of the to-be-famous Rudyard. This is the moment when two periods in history intersect.

Ratan—son of Arjun Oak whose mind and body is degenerating a little more each day, husband of Prema who has left him for another man, one-time doctor now reduced to lab technician—learns with a thrill of precognition that he is part of the mystery that he seeks to unravel. He finds himself morphing into his ancestor, Ramratan Oak who, with three others, were the keepers of a secret that could disease the world. The story of the characters, past as well as their present-day descendants, is told in a revolving-door style that is somewhat confusing; a set of family trees would have been helpful in deciphering the chronology. But although this necessitates a certain amount of flipping back and forth, it in no way detracts from the horrific tale that unfolds: the helplessness of the ordinary citizen against the tyranny of officialdom and the callousness of those paid to protect us. The writing is powerful, the images potent, and the detailed—though sometimes rather too technical—descriptions of cadavers and autopsies make it abundantly clear that the writers (Kalpish Ratna is an almost-anagram of the names of Ishrat Syed and Kalpana Swaminathan) are surgeons. This book is too disturbing to be enjoyable. But it is compelling in that it forces us to recognise that whether beneath the heel of our white colonial masters or that of their brown successors, nothing has changed for the average Indian. ■